taxis, and to the traffic police. The trio (Sivarasan, Shubha and Nero) was believed to be travelling in autorickshaws.

Around that time, an anonymous call from the Bangalore airport shook everyone in the SIT. The caller said he was travelling on the Cochin–Madras flight via Bangalore and was sure that Sivarasan was his co-passenger. It was a stop-over flight, and the caller had got off at Bangalore, but Sivarasan had continued to Madras. Raju informed the Madras Police. Airport security swung into action and surrounded the flight as soon as it landed. The man suspected to be Sivarasan was quietly picked up and brought to Malligai, but he turned out to be the branch manager of a nationalized bank. There were similar anonymous calls one after another. The SIT and the police couldn't ignore even a single one of them. As a result, the SIT ended up catching criminals who were not known to the local police—be it a smuggler, a drug dealer, a forger of passports or a dealer of illicit foreign exchange. Such was the enormity of the case and its investigation that it started to take a toll on the officers.[3]

Ragothaman had lost considerable weight; Verma and Kanth had dark circles around their eyes from lack of sleep; some had started smoking more frequently. There was hardly any communication with their families. One day over lunch, Kaarthikeyan shared with his team that he had laid down a few conditions with Vijay Karan before accepting the assignment of heading the SIT. One of those was that he would visit his family in Hyderabad once a week. He had done that only twice on his way back from Delhi.

The SIT had taken Vicky and Raghu from the custody of the Coimbatore Police to Madras. Both belonged to the LTTE's political group and worked under Trichy Santhan, who was entrusted with the safety of Sivarasan and his escape from India. Kaarthikeyan knew Vicky and Guna had to be cracked soon to get to Trichy Santhan. The news of his arrest must have put the political group on high alert. Trichy Santhan could be anywhere between Trichy, Salem and Coimbatore, where wounded LTTE men underwent treatment in designated 'safe houses'. Vicky had also anticipated Sivarasan taking some steps on his own to escape, if not totally convinced